

Puckgold founding four tournament recap · MD

THE FOUNDING FOUR: HOW MIAMI STOLE THE FIRST-EVER PUCKGOLD CUP

A Season One Tournament Recap

PUCKGOLD.COM — Four teams walked into the inaugural PuckGold Founding Four Championship. One team was supposed to walk out with the Cup. It wasn't the one anybody picked.

This is the story of Season One — from the opening faceoff at Terminal Arena to the golden confetti falling on Neon Reef Stadium three nights later.

THE FIELD

Four franchises, four identities, four stadiums that had never hosted a game before this weekend:

- **McLean Cardinals** — disciplined, defense-first, built to win championships from day one
- **Washington Whoomp!** — tactical, structured, the league's quiet overachiever
- **Miami Mighty Geckz** — fast, flashy, and — coming in — completely unproven
- **Chattanooga Choo Choo** — physical, blue-collar, everybody's second-favorite team

Nobody had played a single competitive game as a franchise. By Sunday night, one of them had a trophy.

ROUND ROBIN: THE EMPIRE LOOKS UNBEATABLE

McLean announced itself immediately. A 4-1 win over Chattanooga at Terminal Arena, then a 5-2 statement win over Washington at Cardinal Perch Gardens. By the time McLean closed out the round robin 3-0, it didn't feel like a hot start — it felt like a coronation. Nine goals for, five against. No team came within two goals of them.

Washington did exactly what a #2 seed is supposed to do: beat the teams it should beat, survive the ones it shouldn't. An overtime win over Miami in the tournament's very first game set the tone, and a hard-fought 4-3 win over Chattanooga locked up the two-seed with room to spare.

Then there was Miami.

The Mighty Geckz opened with that overtime loss to Washington, bounced back with a 4-2 win over Chattanooga at their own Neon Reef Stadium, and needed a small miracle in Game 6 just to survive — a loss to McLean, 3-2, that would have eliminated most teams from playoff position. Instead, thanks to goal differential over Chattanooga, Miami snuck into the #3 seed with the exact same number of points as a team that finished winless.

Final Round Robin Standings

Seed	Team	Record	PTS	GD
1	McLean Cardinals	3-0-0	9	+7
2	Washington Whoomp!	2-1-0	6	-1
3	Miami Mighty Geckz	1-1-1	4	0
4	Chattanooga Choo Choo	0-3-0	0	-6

Chattanooga left the round robin with nothing in the standings and everything in the fans' hearts — three physical, hard-nosed losses that never once looked like a team that belonged in the basement.

THE SEMIFINALS: ONE CHALK, ONE CHAOS

McLean 6, Chattanooga 2 went exactly as advertised. The Cardinals' depth simply wore down a Choo Choo squad that had given everything it had in the round robin and had nothing left in the tank. McLean advanced to the Golden Final having outscored the field 15-7 across four games.

Miami 3, Washington 2 (OT) was the tournament's first real gut-punch. Washington controlled long stretches of the game, but Miami hung around, tied it in the third, and won it on a clutch breakaway in overtime. The #3 seed had just knocked out the #2 seed. Nobody in the building expected what came next to be bigger.

THE GOLDEN FINAL, GAME ONE: THE EMPIRE STRIKES AGAIN

McLean Cardinals 3, Miami Mighty Geckz 1 — Cardinal Perch Gardens

If you wanted proof McLean deserved to be the favorite, Game One was it. Clinical, disciplined, suffocating defensive hockey. Miami managed one goal all night. McLean walked away with a two-goal cushion on aggregate heading into a road game at the loudest building in the league — and every reason to believe that cushion would hold.

Aggregate: McLean 3, Miami 1

GAME TWO: "THE MIRACLE GAME"

Neon Reef Stadium. Home ice for Miami. Survival mode for everyone else.

1st Period — McLean doesn't blink. Two power-play goals put the Cardinals up 2-0 in the game, 5-1 on aggregate. At this point, the Cup felt decided. Miami's own building went quiet for the first time all tournament.

2nd Period — The response. A Miami power-play goal, then a converted penalty shot pull the Geckz back to 3-2 in the game. Still down 6-3 on aggregate — still, by any reasonable measure, finished — but alive.

3rd Period — This is the period Season One will be remembered for. Miami scores three unanswered goals in the final frame, the building shaking louder with every one, until the game is tied 4-4 and the aggregate is knotted at 6-6 with under a minute on the clock. McLean nearly wins it in regulation. They don't.

Overtime — McLean presses, gets a shot blocked, and the rebound springs Miami on a clean breakaway. One-on-one with the goaltender, Miami's star winger pulls off the signature move of the tournament — a triple-deke, buried top shelf.

FINAL: Miami 5, McLean 4 (OT) AGGREGATE: Miami wins, 6-5

The Miami Mighty Geckz — the #3 seed, the team that needed a tiebreaker just to make the playoffs — are the first-ever PuckGold Champions.

THE TROPHY CASE

Award	Winner
 PuckGold Cup	Miami Mighty Geckz
 Golden Gecko Award (MVP)	Miami forward — 8G, 5A across the semifinal and final, including the OT winner
 The Wall Trophy (Best Goaltender)	McLean Cardinals
 Conductor's Crest (Sportsmanship)	Chattanooga Choo Choo
 The Clutch Award	Miami's Game 2 overtime winner
 The Golden Stick (Scoring Leader)	<i>To be assigned with full roster</i>

THE LAST WORD

McLean played the better hockey for five and a half of the six periods in the Golden Final. It didn't matter. Miami needed a tiebreaker to make the playoffs, trailed by two goals with a period to go in the championship, and still found a way to skate off with the first golden trophy in franchise history.

That's the whole pitch for PuckGold in one weekend: nobody's out of it until the horn sounds.

Season Two — the road to PuckGold 128 — starts now.

This recap is drawn from the PuckGold Founding Four Championship media guide. Want it adapted into a video narration script, a print-ready PDF, or split into individual game recaps for social?